



What is housekeeping?

When we think of “housekeeping” we tend to think of the common phrase: “A place for everything and everything in its place.” But housekeeping means more than this.

Good housekeeping means having no unnecessary items about and keeping all necessary items in their proper places.

What is so important about housekeeping?

Think about what could happen if a bunch of oily rags suddenly caught fire one night, or if, in an emergency, employees could not get out of the work area safely because aisles were cluttered. Imagine those same employees unable to get out altogether because of a blocked exit.

Good housekeeping is an essential part of Landscapers INC health and safety program.

What are the benefits of good housekeeping at work?

Good housekeeping at work benefits both employers and employees alike. Good housekeeping can:

- Eliminate clutter which is a common cause of accidents, such as slips, trips, and falls, and fires and explosions.
- Reduce the chances of harmful materials entering the body (e.g., dust, vapors); improve productivity (the right tools and materials for the job will be easy to find); improve your company's image, good housekeeping reflects a well-run business. An orderly workplace will impress all who enter it – employees, visitors, customers, etc.
- Help your company to keep its inventory to a minimum (good housekeeping makes it easier to keep an accurate count of inventories); help your company to make the best use of its space.
- Make the workplace neat, comfortable, and pleasant – not a dangerous eyesore.

Keeping work areas organized and clean can help make work safer, healthier, and easier
Housekeeping at Work



What are some signs of poor housekeeping?

There are many signs of poor housekeeping. You may recognize some of these in your own workplace:

- Cluttered and poorly arranged work areas.
- Untidy or dangerous storage of materials (for example, materials stuffed in corners; overcrowded shelves).
- Dusty, dirty floors and work surfaces.
- items that are in excess or no longer needed.
- Blocked or cluttered aisles and exits.
- Tools and equipment left in work areas instead of being returned to proper storage places, broken containers and damaged materials.
- Overflowing waste bins and containers.
- Spills and leaks.

How to improve housekeeping in your workplace?

Good housekeeping requires effort and teamwork, but it's worth it.

Set housekeeping standards. Make sure they are clear, objective, and attainable. Standards should make work easier, safer, and healthier. It is best to involve employees when setting standards.

Measure how well the standards are met. (Remember: what gets measured gets done.)

Use checklists to help you to systematically measure housekeeping.

Provide positive feedback. Let employees know how well they are doing and how to improve.

Encourage housekeeping as a way of life – not just a special activity when visitors are coming.

Whether your workplace is an office, plant, store, or warehouse, here are some recommended housekeeping practices:

- Follow safe work procedures and the requirements of the law.
- Keep work areas clean.
- Keep aisles clear.
- Keep exits and entrances clear.
- Keep floors clean, dry and in good condition.
- Vacuum or wet sweep dusty areas frequently.
- Stack and store items safely.
- Store all work materials (for example, paper, products, flammable liquids, etc.) in approved, clearly labelled containers in designated storage areas only.
- Use proper waste containers.
- Keep sprinklers, fire alarms and fire extinguishers clear.
- Clean up spills and leaks of any type quickly and properly.
- Clean and store tools, items and equipment properly. Fix or report broken or damaged tools, equipment, etc. Keep lighting sources clean and clear.

